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MESSINES TRENCH

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At exactly 3:10 am on June 7, 1917, 19 huge mines planted in tunnels dug by Allied sappers (engineers) explode under the feet of German soldiers defending Messines Ridge, while shells rain down. At the same moment, Allied tanks and troops begin an assault on the German trenches in an attempt to push them back.

1 Allied army

Troops from Britain, Ireland, Australia, and New Zealand storm the German lines.

2 The battlefield

This muddy mess of craters and burned trees between trenches is known as No-Man's-Land.

3 Powerful weapons

Heavy guns fire 60-lb (27-kg) shells at the German trenches, aiming to destroy their artillery.

4 Bulletproof

Bullets bounce off this British Mark IV tank as it crawls toward the enemy trench.

5 Fix bayonets!

Allied soldiers leap down into the trench, preparing for close combat with the enemy.

6 Lighting up

This flare brightens the night sky. Its light helps defenders spot approaching troops.

7 German engineering

Trench defenses include sandbags, strong walls, shelters, and raised steps to shoot from.

8 Taken by surprise

These soldiers were relaxing when the attack began. They need to get into position fast!

9 Communications

Soldiers used "field telephones" connected by wire to contact HQ. Often wires were cut.

10 Dogfighting

High overhead, Allied S.E.5as and Sopwith Triplanes battle German Albatros D.IIIs.

11 Boom!

These explosions are caused by mines planted in tunnels deep below the trenches.

